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Kolehiyo Central: A Centralized College Application Platform for Philippine Universities

I. Introduction

A. Rationale

As of July 26, 2025, the Philippines had 2,334 higher education institutions (HEIs), both public and private *(CHED, 2025)*, offering students various opportunities to pursue a college education. To make higher education more accessible, the government has expanded free higher education, benefiting approximately 2.62 million students *(PCO, 2026)*, and provided scholarships to help students with financial difficulties. However, despite these efforts, many students continue to face barriers to pursuing higher education (~~*Merlina*~~ *Hernando-Malipot, 2026)*. Financial limitations are not the only concern. Difficulties in finding reliable admission information, understanding application procedures, and completing requirements can also prevent students from accessing available opportunities.

These challenges are also reflected in the college admission process itself. In a qualitative study, Cananua-Labid et al. (2026) identified problems such as complicated and inconsistent admission procedures, admission criteria that may disadvantage certain groups of students, limited transparency, and unequal access to information. For students with limited resources or access to guidance, navigating these requirements can be especially difficult. They may need to search through different websites and sources, compare admission requirements, and keep track of multiple application deadlines. Managing these tasks separately can make the process time-consuming and overwhelming, potentially causing students to miss opportunities to apply.

A more organized approach to college applications can help address these difficulties. In the United States, the Common Application (Common App) allows students to apply to more than 1,200 participating colleges and universities through a shared application platform (The Common Application, Inc., 2025). In a study by Knight and Schiff (2022), colleges that adopted the Common Application received more applications. This finding suggests that centralized application platforms can make it easier for students to apply to multiple institutions and consider a wider range of college options. By bringing application processes together, these platforms can also lessen the burden of managing separate applications.

The feasibility of digital solutions for college admissions is also supported by research in the Philippines. Bordios et al. (2026) developed and initially evaluated the Unified College Admission System (UCAS), a digital platform designed to support admissions across State Universities and Colleges (SUCs). The system allows students to submit applications through a shared platform while helping institutions organize application records and coordinate admission processes. Its initial evaluation reported positive results in ease of use, efficiency, and reliability. These findings demonstrate the potential of digital platforms to improve college admission processes within the Philippine higher education setting.

Despite these developments, students still lack a single, accessible platform where they can find and organize admission information from different higher education institutions. They continue to rely on multiple sources to explore college

options, understand admission requirements, and monitor application deadlines. This highlights the need for a centralized resource that makes these processes easier to navigate.

To address this gap, Kolehiyo Central is proposed as a centralized college application platform designed to help Filipino students explore and prepare for higher education opportunities. The platform will provide a directory of colleges and universities where students can access information about academic programs, admission requirements, application procedures, and deadlines in one place. It will also feature scholarship opportunities and transfer programs, helping students discover different pathways to higher education. In addition, students will be able to organize and monitor their applications, keep track of required documents, and receive reminders about important deadlines. By bringing these resources and tools together, Kolehiyo Central aims to make college admission information easier to access, simplify application management, and help students make more informed decisions about their educational future.

B. Objectives

The primary objective of Kolehiyo Central is to develop a centralized and user-friendly college application platform that simplifies the process of applying to multiple universities in the Philippines. Through this project, ReachUp Education aims to address common challenges faced by college applicants, including managing different application websites, keeping track of admission requirements and deadlines, and repeatedly preparing and submitting documents. The platform seeks to provide students with a more organized, convenient, and accessible way to manage their college applications while promoting equal access to higher education opportunities.

Specifically, the project aims to:

1. Develop a centralized college application platform where students can create personal accounts, provide their academic information, select universities, and manage multiple college applications through a single system.
2. Simplify the submission and management of admission requirements by allowing applicants to upload general application documents and provide additional requirements based on the specific admission policies of their chosen universities.
3. Provide organized and reliable university admission information by presenting application requirements, procedures, and deadlines in one accessible platform, with information verified and updated through coordination with participating universities.
4. Improve the efficiency of the college application process by reducing the time and effort students spend navigating separate university application websites, preparing repetitive information, and monitoring their application progress.
5. Promote accessibility and equal opportunities in higher education by providing a convenient platform that assists college applicants, particularly students with limited access to educational guidance and reliable admission information.
6. Evaluate the functionality, usability, and effectiveness of the platform through an initial pilot implementation in selected areas of Metro Manila with limited

participating universities, using user feedback and system testing to identify potential improvements before further expansion.

C. Benefits

The implementation of Kolehiyo Central is expected to benefit college applicants, participating universities, and the broader education sector by improving the accessibility, organization, and efficiency of the college application process. By integrating university admission information and application services into a single platform, the project aims to simplify application procedures and support students in pursuing higher education opportunities. [i can expound on this more if the page limit permits - harvi]

II. Project Description

A. Methodology

To develop, deploy, and evaluate Kolehiyo Central, the project will follow a five-phase implementation process using an Agile development framework. This process moves from field research and technical system design to functional programming, security validation, and pilot calibration.

1. Information Gathering and Research
    - Collect verified admission steps, degree programs, course overviews, tuition fees, and scholarship criteria across target Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) in Metro Manila (UAAP and NCAA schools) and government agencies (DOST-SEI Undergraduate Scholarship).
    - Interview high school registrars and guidance counselors to document the average number of days required to issue student records (Form 137, Good Moral certificates, etc.) to set earlier deadline reminders.
    - List and map out physical testing sites, admissions offices, and campus locations so applicants know where to go.
2. System Planning and Setup
    - Plan a website that works reliably on both smartphones and desktop computers.
    - Organize the system so new universities, colleges, and scholarship programs can be added later without rebuilding the website.
    - Set clear account permissions so students only see their own documents, while university staff can only view applicants applying to their school.
3. Feature Development
    - Create an all-in-one dashboard showing available schools to apply, application statuses, and test dates so students do not mix up or double-book deadlines.
    - Build a central folder where students upload records, paired with automated alerts that warn them well before documents are due.
    - Build search filters that let students find course offerings, tuition fees, scholarships, and find nearby exam centers.
    - Create a portal for partner universities to check student files, verify requirements, and post updates.
    - Provide students with a shareable completion template or confirmation slip for every successfully submitted application.
4. Security and System Testing

- Follow the Philippine Data Privacy Act (RA 10173) by encrypting personal records and uploaded files to prevent unauthorized access.
- Test the website for bugs, slow loading times, and security weakness before releasing it to users.

5. Pilot Testing and Review
   - Release the platform to test a group of Grade 12 Senior High School students in Metro Manila applying to participating schools.
   - Give students and school staff short surveys to measure how easy, clear, and convenient the platform is to use.
   - Track key numbers, such as how long it takes to finish an application and test whether the platform successfully prevents missed deadlines.

B. Timeline and Budget

Table 1. Timeline for Project Milestones

Task	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May
Phase 1						
Information gathering						
Interviews and mapping						
Website planning and design						
Phase 2						
Database and system architecture						
Access controls and permissions						
Phase 3						
Dashboard and application tracker						
Document upload and reminders						
Search filters and database						
University partner portal						
Confirmation slip feature						
Phase 4						
Encryption and privacy safeguards						
System and security testing						
Bug fixing and optimization						
Phase 5						
Pilot recruitment and coordination						

Pilot deployment	
Surveys and performance evaluation	
Final revisions and evaluation	

The projected total duration for the project research and implementation is approximately six months, starting from December until the end of May, with overlaps between the different phases to allow previous activities to be utilized in the ongoing developments of each phase. The first two months will be dedicated to research and planning to gather information on the targeted stakeholders and establish the system's foundations.

The third and fourth month will be utilized in the development of the site to include major platform features, integrate university portals, and implement data protection measures. Upon the projected completion of site development, the fourth and fifth month will be used for testing and deployment preparation to conduct security and functionality testing, resolve technical issues, and prepare participating schools and students for pilot implementation.

The final fifth and sixth months will be dedicated to pilot testing and evaluation to allow deployment of the platform to the selected Grade 12 students, gather feedback, measure application efficiency, and implement final improvements. Overall, the anticipated six-month implementation timeline ensures systematic development and continuous improvement of Kolehiyo Central.

III. Conclusion

IV. References

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